

Connecting Climate Minds

Youth Declaration

We, a collective youth of the Connecting Climate Mind project from diverse socio-economic and cultural backgrounds from twenty-three countries, came together in a series of youth dialogues to share perspectives and lived experience insights on the intersection of climate change and mental health. The recommendations outlined here were gathered from three youth-led dialogues (in India, Nigeria and globally), and were finalized through a thematic analysis and synthesis of responses.

Noting that there are over 1.8 billion young people globally with 90% of this population domiciled in developing countries, the world can reap from this demographic advantage in shaping climate change and mental health research and action. We bear unique mental health experiences and can facilitate and influence action towards promoting positive mental health outcomes amidst the global climate crisis.

This youth declaration represents the latest findings and recommendations stemming from youth dialogues held within the Connecting Climate Minds project. It is our sincere hope that these recommendations will be earnestly considered and acted upon by relevant stakeholders.



Our shared *aspirations* are encapsulated in the following principles:

1. **Hope, Resilience, and Sustainability:** By acknowledging the mental health impacts of climate change, we, the young people, aim to inspire action and purpose in the face of climate-related adversity. We hope this is achieved by encouraging older decision-makers to recognize our ability to adapt and to understand that our unique resilience methods can inform strategies to reduce climate-related mental health challenges, like youth-centred mental health services and platforms at all levels of care. We also hope that actions taken to address this issue are environmentally sustainable and do not exacerbate mental health challenges.
2. **Thriving Youth and Healthy Environments:** We seek a world where young people thrive beyond the current realities of fear and neglect and can embrace a green and healthy future free from flooding, droughts, and climate-related risks. Our vision includes resilient ecosystems, biomimicry-inspired structures (a design that draws inspiration from nature's solutions to address human challenges), and clean air fostering well-being for all.
3. **Prioritizing Lived Experiences, Inclusion and Autonomy:** As young people, we desire a world where our contributions are required, heard, and relevant. We are also calling for the frontlining of lived experience perspectives in global climate change and mental health research while also avoiding tokenism. Furthermore, we call for the retention of community wisdom and practices in global research and that research spaces are decolonised and prioritize the narratives and experiences of marginalized and underrepresented communities. This ensures that their voices are central to decision-making processes and that their knowledge is respected and valued.

By this Youth Declaration, we *desire*:

- I. That, to successfully transform our world, the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is adopted and actualised by all stakeholders, thereby prioritising national and international policies that implement, monitor and achieve climate change and mental health-related SDGs.
- II. The vital role and contribution of youth organizations, youth movements, networks and other youth-led entities, in helping build a safer and more sustainable society for young people. We also recognise the continued support of the youth sector as a whole, together with ministries/departments of youth and other stakeholders, in furthering youth development.
- III. The support and sensitization of communities in addressing the stigma surrounding climate-induced mental health challenges. This would enable young people to better cope

with the trauma, invalidation, and hopelessness resulting from environmental disasters and compounding economic instability that affects mental well-being.

- IV. Adequate and timely support from the government in climate-aware mental health support and initiatives to create a conducive environment for thriving.

On the strength of the foregoing, we oblige relevant stakeholders in climate change and mental health to commit to meaningful, inclusive, and systemic embedding of youth engagement and integration of mental health in climate change initiatives (and vice versa), including policy development, research, capacity-building, and community engagement. Additionally, we urge the integration of these efforts into national climate action plans, international climate agreements, and mental health policy frameworks.

We further urge for the implementation of the *resolutions* outlined here;

- V. **Prioritize the inclusion of youth perspectives** in climate-mental health education as this will strengthen youth inclusion in specific resilience and adaptation plans. Furthermore, promoting youth involvement in decision-making processes and research ensures their perspectives shape research agendas and public policy priorities by fully integrating a bottom-up approach.
- VI. **Integrate climate change** concerns into policies and programmes dealing with mental health. Conversely, this includes Mental Health and Psychosocial Support (MHPSS) being embedded into policies and programmes that deal with climate change and health in order to better prepare for and respond to the climate crisis.
- VII. **Supporting experts to implement multisectoral and community-based approaches** to reduce vulnerabilities and address the mental health and psychosocial impacts of climate change among young people.
- VIII. **Increased funding for research** in climate change and mental health and supporting lived experience research in order to identify key areas for targeted interventions that address the specific needs of young people. This includes providing expertise and technical support, exchange and internship opportunities.
- IX. **Prioritize investment** in capacity building for mental health practitioners, facilitate innovation, and enhance data gathering initiatives, as these efforts will help identify local challenges, as well as solutions, in climate change and mental health.
- X. **Implement a stepped-care approach** by training people within affected communities to deliver interventions for populations who are at risk or who have been affected by acute events, either in the preparatory stage or aftermath of events. These approaches could include; basic psychological response training, stress management strategies and sociocultural resilience training.
- XI. **Support and advance equitable** collaborative efforts led by youth that actively involve and engage young people in initiatives related to climate and mental health, and amplify their voices at the highest levels. This includes providing an enabling environment for young

people as a driving force for action to address the mental health challenges posed by climate change

- XII. **Foster new pathways** to finance and scale up youth-led climate resilient and sustainability projects (sustainable financing) even at the grassroots level and also support strong mechanisms for equitable access to climate financing to ensure inclusivity and fairness in youth-led projects at the intersections of climate change and mental health.
- XIII. **Establish and promote access** to specialized mental health support services and resources focusing on climate-aware therapy, ensuring the provision of accessible, affordable, non-discriminatory and confidential mental health support services for young people when and where they need it. Additionally, to also implement effective and accessible programs for monitoring and responding to mental health challenges and strengthening psychological resilience amidst the climate crisis.
- XIV. **Promote effective and inclusive** networking platforms for youth to share their knowledge and lived experiences encouraging youth inclusion at all levels.
- XV. **Integrate nature-based solutions** and interventions into mental health care, promoting education on nature's benefits, supporting research and innovation, and ensuring policy integration while recognizing the significant potential for nature-based solutions to contribute to effective actions for climate and mental health resilience development.

With these aspirations being inspired by the outcomes of the Connecting Climate Minds youth dialogues, we, the young people, solicit the support and commitment of world leaders and relevant stakeholders to this declaration. Given this, we envision a future where young people are actively engaged in the solutions we have laid out, ensuring that a sustainable and equitable world is achievable even for generations to come. This future hinges on collaborative efforts, where the voices and actions of every young person, community, and nation contribute to a global movement towards climate resilience and strong mental health. We call for a paradigm shift in how we perceive and address these challenges, emphasizing inclusivity, innovation, and empowerment.

With this youth declaration, we lay these recommendations and desires in hopes for stakeholders to consider in future policy and action for climate change and mental health.

Commitment

I _____ pledge to the commitments of this declaration, to advocate for increased awareness of the mental health impacts of climate change, destigmatizing mental health issues, and promoting resilience-building strategies for both climate hazards and their mental health and psychosocial consequences. To engage with decision-makers to prioritize mental health in climate change adaptation and mitigation strategies, ensuring inclusivity and equity. Furthermore, to support and engage in research and empower communities to take action. To collaborate with organizations and youth movements, centring the voices of those directly impacted and holding ourselves accountable for our commitments as we seek a sustainable and resilient world for all.

[Submit your commitment here](#)